

How to: One-on-One

A Six-Year Retrospective

No Magic Pill

What Are 1:1s?

- Meet with a partner once a week and discuss your life
 - Problems
 - Thoughts
 - Ideas
 - Decisions
 - General well-being
 - Etc
- You should be bringing everything on your mind to the 1:1 session
- Lots of rationalist techniques and jedi mind tricks apply: debugging, goal factoring, Hamming questions, [insert every CFAR technique here]

Why Do 1:1s Work?

- Feedback
 - Offers pos/neg reinforcement, the chance for someone to tell you you're an idiot, etc
- Second brain
 - Imagine two of you, but the other has a completely different life, set of experiences, expertise, mental models, opinions. If you trust this person, then you can get some very valuable thoughts!
- Accountability
 - Similar to coworking (you should try Focusmate if you haven't!)
- Conviction
 - Both partners are doing this because they *know* it's good for them, thus they put in effort, thus it becomes more valuable, completing the loop

What Makes a Good 1:1 Partner

- Preparation: have a list of things you've done, want to do, have thought about
- Effort!
 - Try to make the other person better!
 - Challenge and push back on each other!
 - Ask why, how
 - Notice things: do they respond well to certain incentives (losing money, shame, etc)
- Differences in personality and lifestyle and expertise: good and bad
 - Optimal is probably some overlap, not none and not all
- LLMs can supplement, but can't replace (yet) (at least for me)
 - In person > virtual >> LLM >>> nothing
- Stranger vs. friend: stranger for honesty, friend for caring; preferably a stranger that you can become best friends with

How'd I Get My 1:1 Partner?

1. I read Ben Kuhn's blog post *The unreasonable effectiveness of 1:1s*
2. I thought "wow, that's a great idea! I wish I had someone like that!"
3. I posted an open thread on r/slatestarcodex to see if others were interested
4. ...
5. Six years later, we still meet ~1 time per week (and he's my best friend)

My Session Structure

Weekly

1. Partner 1 talks about their life:
 - a. 15 min last week: to-dos, reflections, etc
 - b. 10 min plans for next week
 - c. 5 min miscellaneous thoughts
2. Repeat for partner 2
3. ???
4. Profit!

Yearly

1. Same as weekly, but for the past year and the coming year

Things My 1:1s Have Helped Me With

- Starting and maintaining my personal website, which probably led me here
- Finding blind spots and what I respond well to
- Eliminating fuckarounditis
- Learning new practices: Beeminder, TAPs, Focusmate
- Methods of installing TAPs
- Implementing mindfulness throughout the day
- Splitting my workday into 4-4 or 6-2 to get more sunlight/outside availability
- Experiment designs
- How to approach a meeting with a congressman
- Marriage and children as a contributor or subtractor of happiness
- FIRE considerations

Things Our 1:1s Have Helped **My Partner** With

- Not selling investments mid-COVID #HODL
- Speeding up job applications
- Using AI more
- Help with hobby
- Big life decisions e.g. whether to meditate
- Tons of micro decisions

Partner Matching Time!

- Raise your hand if you're down to find a 1:1 partner right here, right now
 - They can be in this room or in your personal life (friend, family, partner, etc)
 - Conditions:
 - Commit to meeting virtually 1 hr/week for 3 months
 - (Optional, but highly preferred!) Contact NMP with results of your meetings
 - (Also optional, but even more highly preferred!) Write a blog post about it

